

The End of Mythology

We are well past the Day-After disbelief. We have seen the winner's struggle in the distribution of the spoils of victory. And Dr Manmohan Singh has already begun the second lap of his journey which we hope will be smoother than the first. This column, though, is about the losers, about the limits of mythology in an age when nations prefer dreaming the future to fantasising about the long lost yesterday. We are talking about losers united by the redundancy of the kind of politics that draws its sustenance from monochromatic mythos. The Loser Number One is the BJP, the greatest letdown in Indian politics. The commentariat would like to impale an old man for all the sins of the party he built. The BJP's problem is bigger than the individual tragedy of Lal Krishna Advani, who is not your average Moses who never reached the Promised Land. There has been no promised land. But there was promise—and a blast of romance—when India got its first right-wing government, and for once charisma rhymed with a name other than Gandhi. The post-Vajpayee BJP is a story of stagnation and defeatism. It has missed the drumbeats of history as it followed echoes from mythology. It missed the ideas of the times as it continued to torture itself for acquiring an ideological identity. In the end, there was not a single idea from the party that captured the imagination of India; and the party remained ideologically amorphous. The BJP today is a party of remoteness.

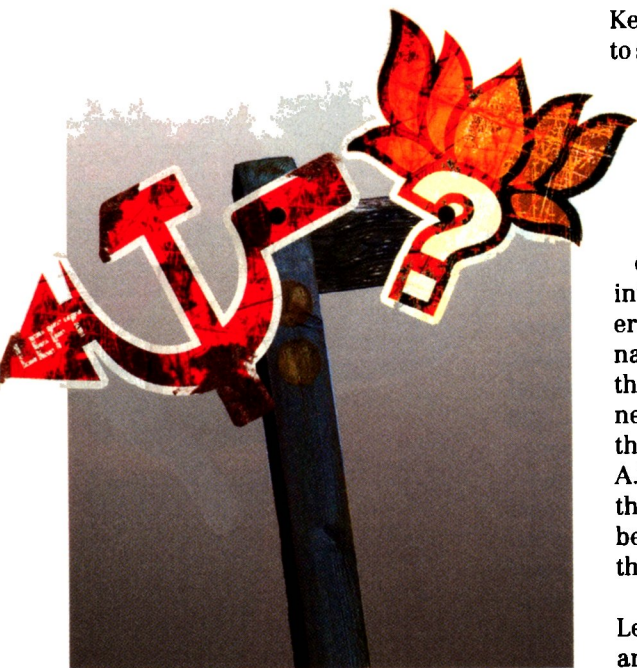
The other loser is the one that has already lost the argument with history. It is the last vestige of what was once the biggest superstition that swayed mankind. Today, in any civilised society, being a communist is as trendy as being a Druid, a Templar, a

Freemason, or an Illuminatus. The Indian communists have long ago lost India: the little soviets they keep in Kerala and West Bengal are a tribute to sub-rural patience—or the triumph of political thuggery. The shrunken Marxism is the best that has come out of this election. After almost five years of political harlotry, Indian communists, even in their current downsized state, are capable of interpreting the defeat as a minor error in practice. For, in the hallucinations of the troglodytes who control the party, the science of communism never fails. This election broke the myth that the inhabitants of A.K.G. Bhavan wanted to perpetuate: the fall of the Soviet empire could be undone by the empowerment of the Third Front.

So what have we got between the Left and the Right? Ideological junk and ideological blackout.



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SAURABH SINGH

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Writer and poet **Kamala Das**, 75, who authored *My Story*, *The Sirens*, *Summer in Calcutta* and *Alphabet of Lust*. She converted to Islam in 1999 and changed her name to **Kamala Suraiyya**.



DIED: Cartoonist and filmmaker **K.P. Thomas**, 75. He had won the national award for the best producer for the film *Manimuzhakkam*.

WON: By **Sandeep Singh**, the silver medal at the **AIBA World Junior Boxing Championships** in **Yerevan, Armenia**. The **junior Indian team** won a total of **four medals**.

CONFERRED: On Wipro chairman **Azim Premji**, the **Doctor of Humane Letters** by **Wesleyan University, Connecticut**, for his achievements as a renowned entrepreneur and global business leader.

